On August 29, the day on which CIA overflights located Soviet surface-to-air missiles on the island, Kennedy publicly denied the possible presence of Soviet troops in Cuba and American plans to invade the island. Once again, Berlin was on his mind. He stated: “The United States has obligations all around the world, including West Berlin and other areas, which are very sensitive, and, therefore, I think that in considering what appropriate action we should take, we have to consider the totality of our obligations, and also the responsibilities which we bear in so many different parts of the world.” The worst thing that could happen, in Kennedy’s view, was that his actions in Cuba might provoke a crisis in West Berlin, leading to a Soviet blockade of the city, a US-Soviet military confrontation, and eventually a nuclear war.[19]

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JOHN KENNEDY RETURNED TO WASHINGTON FROM HIS LABOR Day weekend on the morning of Tuesday, September 4, to confer with his foreign policy team. The key discussion item was a statement that the president had asked Rusk to draft before departing for the holiday. The secretary of state suggested the deployment of offensive weapons as the red line that Khrushchev would be warned not to cross. “Any placing by the Soviets of significant offensive capability in the hands of the self-announced aggressive regime in Cuba would be a direct and major challenge to this hemisphere and would warrant immediate and appropriate action,” read the draft statement.

Rusk failed to clarify what constituted “offensive weapons” and what the “appropriate action” might be. On the first issue, McNamara argued that the deployment of Soviet MiG fighters would fit the bill. Bundy suggested instead that “surface to surface missiles are the turning point.” Regarding “appropriate action,” Bundy argued that, given the consequences of a nuclear exchange to the United States, the Americans would be better off not taking any aggressive action vis-à-vis Cuba. Not only McNamara but also Rusk disagreed with Bundy and considered invasion necessary if nuclear-armed missiles were to be spotted on the island. Rusk believed that